

SOE Human Artist Visual Identity Brief

System of Eternity / Non-Terminal Research

Purpose: human artist handoff package for professional logo and visual identity development. This package does not lock a final logo, authorize public claims, or make any research-readiness claim.

SOE Human Artist Design Brief

Project

Design a visual identity system for:

System of Eternity

SOE

SOE is a civilizational governance research framework under the broader public research hub:

Non-Terminal Research

<https://nonterminal.org/>

SOE is not a political party, not a tech product, not a utopian ideology, and not an implementation-ready governance system. It is a theoretical governance architecture for long-horizon institutional continuity, adjudication, source boundaries, controlled revision, and non-terminal self-correction.

Design Goal

The identity should make SOE feel:

- ? serious,
- ? institutional,
- ? restrained,
- ? durable,
- ? research-oriented,
- ? long-horizon,
- ? structurally intelligent,
- ? open to revision without looking unstable.

The mark should feel like it belongs on:

- ? a working paper,
- ? an academic research website,
- ? a long-term institutional framework,
- ? a governance architecture document,
- ? an archive or standards-like research body.

Core Meaning

SOE is built around this idea:

continuity without final closure

The identity may lightly suggest:

- ? revision without collapse,

- ? structure without rigidity,
- ? continuity under change,
- ? governance that can update itself,
- ? non-terminal institutional design.

Do not over-literalize this. The logo does not need to explain SOE by itself. Many strong marks do not carry heavy explicit meaning; they become meaningful through repeated use, quality, and association. SOE needs a mark that feels right before it tries to say too much.

Existing Visual System To Respect

The current Non-Terminal Research site uses:

- ? ink navy: #07111f
- ? secondary ink: #111d2d
- ? warm paper: #efebe2
- ? paper cool: #f7f5ee
- ? off-white: #fffa0
- ? bronze accent: #a87637
- ? steel blue: #53728d

Typography direction:

- ? editorial serif headings similar to EB Garamond,
- ? clean humanist sans body text similar to Inter,
- ? no futuristic display fonts,
- ? no startup-style rounded wordmark.

The final logo must work in monochrome first. Color is secondary.

Important Correction From Prior Exploration

Earlier explorations used a broken circular O. This created problems:

- ? it looked like a circle with a bite taken out,
- ? it sometimes read as SCE instead of SOE,
- ? it risked looking like a loading spinner,
- ? it risked a reticle or target association,
- ? it did not feel beautiful enough to lock.

Therefore:

Do not assume the final SOE mark must be a broken circle.

A circle, open ring, notch, seam, gate, line, interval, threshold, or typographic intervention may be explored, but the artist should choose the best visual solution.

Preferred Strategy

Start from a wordmark-first identity system.

Priority order:

1. Make SOE read clearly and beautifully.
2. Make System of Eternity feel serious and publishable.

3. Add non-terminal meaning only if it improves the mark.
4. Prove the mark works at small size.
5. Prove the mark works in black and white.

Readable first. Symbolic second.

Aesthetic quality first. Conceptual cleverness last.

Suggested Directions To Explore

These are not mandatory:

- ? refined SOE wordmark with subtle non-closed typographic detail,
- ? editorial wordmark with one controlled interruption or threshold,
- ? linear revision-gate motif instead of a circle,
- ? quiet document seal that does not look governmental or mystical,
- ? typographic ligature or spacing system around SOE,
- ? abstract structural mark paired with the full name.
- ? no overt symbol at all, if the wordmark is strong enough.

Must Avoid

Avoid anything that reads as:

- ? tech startup,
- ? crypto token,
- ? app icon,
- ? loading spinner,
- ? reticle,
- ? military badge,
- ? political party mark,
- ? cult or mystical seal,
- ? sci-fi faction,
- ? national crest,
- ? glowing orbital/cosmic imagery,
- ? generic consulting logo,
- ? overdesigned AI-generated geometry.

Success Test

The final mark should make a serious reader think:

This is a disciplined research framework.

It should not make them think:

This is a movement, product, game faction, ideology, or fantasy world.

SOE Logo Asset Context Matrix

This file records the practical asset system requested from a human artist. It exists because one logo image will not survive every public context cleanly.

Core Principle

Design a flexible visual identity system, not a single static image.

The SOE mark should work across:

- ? small square avatars,
- ? profile pictures,
- ? website headers,
- ? paper covers,
- ? social preview cards,
- ? wide background banners,
- ? presentation title slides.

Different platforms crop images differently. The artist should define safe zones and produce format-specific exports rather than relying on aggressive resizing after the fact.

Requested Asset Families

1. Primary Mark

- ? SOE wordmark or monogram.
- ? Full System of Eternity lockup.
- ? Must work in monochrome.
- ? Must remain readable in small sizes.

2. Avatar / Icon System

Recommended exports:

- ? 16 x 16 px
- ? 32 x 32 px
- ? 64 x 64 px
- ? 128 x 128 px
- ? 512 x 512 px
- ? 1024 x 1024 px

Use cases:

- ? GitHub avatar
- ? Substack avatar
- ? Discord/social avatar
- ? favicon
- ? small profile contexts

The 16 x 16 px and 32 x 32 px versions should be treated as simplified favicon tests. The mark does not need to preserve every detail at those sizes, but it must not collapse into a spinner, target, broken artifact, or unreadable acronym.

3. Wide Header / Banner System

Recommended exports:

- ? 1500 x 500 px for X/Twitter-style header use
- ? 1584 x 396 px for LinkedIn-style background use
- ? 1200 x 630 px for Open Graph / social preview use
- ? 2560 x 1440 px with safe-area guidance for YouTube/presentation/crop-heavy contexts

Use cases:

- ? social media header images
- ? website page banners
- ? research profile cover fields
- ? presentation backgrounds

4. Paper / Archive System

Recommended outputs:

- ? vector PDF mark
- ? SVG mark
- ? title-page lockup
- ? paper-cover version
- ? dark and light variants

Use cases:

- ? Zenodo/arXiv paper covers
- ? report title pages
- ? presentation title slides
- ? PDF front matter

5. Background / Wallpaper System

The background system should be quiet and secondary.

Good directions:

- ? subtle archival texture
- ? restrained structural linework
- ? minimal threshold or interval motif
- ? low-contrast pattern that can sit behind text

Avoid:

- ? loud wallpapers
- ? sci-fi scenes
- ? glowing networks
- ? cosmic/orbital imagery
- ? target-like geometry
- ? political or national imagery

Safe-Zone Requirement

For every major asset family, the artist should provide a safe-zone note:

- ? what area must never be cropped,
- ? where text can safely sit,
- ? what version should be used for square vs wide vs document contexts.

Final Practical Rule

The mark should not depend on one perfect crop. If it only works in one rectangle, it is not ready for public identity use.

SOE Artist Deliverables And File Spec

Required Design Deliverables

Ask the artist for at least three distinct logo directions:

1. Wordmark-first SOE direction
2. Symbol-plus-wordmark direction
3. Conservative typographic fallback direction

Each direction should include:

- ? full lockup: System of Eternity
- ? short lockup: SOE
- ? horizontal version
- ? stacked version
- ? symbol-only or favicon version if a symbol exists
- ? dark background version
- ? light background version
- ? monochrome black version
- ? monochrome white version

Required Export Files

For the final selected direction:

- ? master vector file: .ai, .svg, or .pdf
- ? clean SVG exports
- ? transparent PNG exports
- ? square avatar PNG: 512x512
- ? favicon PNG: 16x16, 32x32, 64x64
- ? social preview PNG: 1200x630
- ? paper-cover/header mark
- ? usage guide PDF or short notes file

Commission Mechanics To Confirm Before Work Begins

Before commissioning the artist, confirm these practical terms in writing:

- ? estimated price or price range,
- ? payment schedule,

- ? expected start date and delivery date,
- ? number of included revision rounds,
- ? cost or process for extra revision rounds,
- ? whether interim concept thumbnails are included,
- ? whether final source files are included,
- ? whether the final identity is exclusive to QianJun Yu / SOE,
- ? whether the work is transferred as work-for-hire or licensed for broad public research use.

The recommended concept process is:

1. Initial monochrome exploration: 6 to 9 thumbnail directions.
2. Select 1 to 2 directions for refinement.
3. Finalize one direction only after small-size tests, monochrome tests, and rights checks pass.

Small-Size Tests

The mark must be tested at:

- ? 16 px favicon
- ? 32 px favicon
- ? 48 px profile icon
- ? 64 px profile icon
- ? 128 px avatar

At those sizes:

- ? SOE should still read as SOE,
- ? no detail should collapse into a spinner,
- ? no detail should look like damage,
- ? no detail should resemble a target or reticle.

Color Tests

Test on:

- ? warm paper background: #efebe2
- ? ink navy background: #07111f
- ? pure white
- ? pure black

The mark must survive in one color.

Website Fit Test

The mark should feel compatible with:

- ? EB Garamond-like headings,
- ? Inter-like body text,
- ? warm paper page background,
- ? ink navy hero/header,

? bronze accent rules.

It does not need to copy the current website motif.

Ownership And Rights

Before using the final logo publicly, confirm:

? QianJun Yu receives permission to use the logo for public research identity,

? commercial or public-web use is allowed,

? modification rights are clear,

? source/vector files are included,

? fonts used are listed and licensed for commercial and public research use,

? no stock-logo template or trademark-conflicting mark is used.

? the artist has checked for obvious visual confusion with existing institutions, universities, public agencies, research organizations, standards bodies, political marks, military marks, or commercial brands.

This is important because the logo may be used on public records, websites, profiles, and publications.

Usage Sheet Requirement

Ask the artist for a one-page usage sheet that includes:

? the preferred primary lockup,

? acceptable light/dark variants,

? minimum size guidance,

? safe-zone rule, preferably expressed numerically,

? crop guidance for square avatars, wide banners, and paper covers,

? a short do/do-not list for future use.

SOE Visual Identity Do / Do Not Guide

Do

? Use restrained geometry.

? Use strong typography.

? Preserve clear reading of SOE.

? Prefer memorability over explanation.

? Let meaning be light and associative.

? Prefer editorial and institutional visual weight.

? Use warm paper and ink-like contrast.

? Make the mark work without color.

? Let the full name carry seriousness:

System of Eternity

? Treat the mark as a research identity, not a campaign identity.

? Leave room for future expansion beyond current papers.

Do Not

- ? Do not force a broken circle.
- ? Do not make the O look bitten, damaged, or chewed away.
- ? Do not make SOE read as SCE.
- ? Do not use four equal circular gaps.
- ? Do not use a centered dot if it creates target or coordinate associations.
- ? Do not animate the mark.
- ? Do not add stars, globes, planets, wings, shields, crowns, flames, triangles, or sacred geometry.
- ? Do not use neon, gradients, chrome, glow, glass, or "AI product" styling.
- ? Do not use red/black political force styling.
- ? Do not use blue corporate SaaS styling.
- ? Do not make the logo carry the whole theory.
- ? Do not accept a clever concept if the mark is ugly.

Design Philosophy

The SOE identity should be quiet enough to survive criticism and strong enough to be remembered.

It should be:

- ? less charismatic than a movement,
- ? less decorative than a brand campaign,
- ? less futuristic than sci-fi,
- ? less literal than an infographic,
- ? more disciplined than a generic personal logo.

It does not need to be a diagram of SOE. It should be a usable identity that can gather meaning over time.

Relationship To Non-Terminal Research

Non-Terminal Research is the broader public hub.

SOE is the main governance research branch.

The SOE mark may eventually be used for:

- ? Zenodo records,
- ? arXiv PDFs,
- ? GitHub/ORCID/social profile images,
- ? paper covers,
- ? website section headers,
- ? future presentation decks.

The SOE mark should harmonize with the website identity but does not need to copy the website motif.

SOE Logo Failure Modes And Rejected Directions

This file records what the artist should avoid based on prior AI exploration and multi-AI review.

Rejected As Final: Broken Circle O With Bite-Like Gap

Problem:

- ? The O looked bitten off.
- ? The mark felt visually awkward rather than elegant.
- ? The concept was defensible, but the execution did not feel good enough for public use.

Why it matters:

- ? A mark can be conceptually correct and still aesthetically wrong.
- ? SOE needs institutional confidence, not a clever diagram.

Rejected As Final: Four-Gap Ring

Problem:

- ? Four equal gaps create crosshair or reticle associations.
- ? It can also read as a loading spinner or UI status icon.
- ? This is especially risky because SOE is a governance framework and must avoid military, targeting, or operational-authority signals.

Rejected As Final: Side-Gap O

Problem:

- ? A strong side gap can make SOE read as SCE.
- ? Readability must come before symbolism.

Rejected As Final: Center Dot Underline

Problem:

- ? A centered dot under a circular O can imply target, coordinate, or ritual mark.
- ? It may still work in some refined lockups, but it should not be assumed.

Rejected As Final: AI Geometry As Logo

Problem:

- ? Some AI-generated marks looked like diagrams, concept sketches, or system icons rather than a real identity.
- ? Human refinement is needed for typography, spacing, optical balance, and emotional register.

Lessons To Preserve

The failed explorations still taught useful constraints:

- ? non-terminal openness is important,
- ? the mark should not close into rigid finality,
- ? a small controlled interruption can be meaningful if it remains beautiful,
- ? the identity should stay quiet and serious,
- ? full wordmark readability matters more than symbolic cleverness.
- ? heavy symbolism can hurt the mark.

Best Current Direction

Use a human-designed, wordmark-first SOE identity.

The final solution may use:

- ? no symbol,

- ? a subtle typographic intervention,
- ? a non-circular open structure,
- ? a line/gate/threshold motif,
- ? a refined O that remains clearly an O.

The designer should not be trapped inside the circle solution.

The designer should also not be trapped inside the idea that the logo must visibly explain "non-terminal governance." A light cue is enough. A strong mark is better than a clever mark.

SOE Logo Review Rubric

Use this rubric when reviewing human artist proposals.

Verdict Options

ACCEPT_SOE_LOGO_DIRECTION

PATCH_SOE_LOGO_DIRECTION

REJECT_SOE_LOGO_DIRECTION

Core Questions

1. Does the mark clearly read as SOE or System of Eternity?
2. Does it look credible for a serious civilizational governance research framework?
3. Does it avoid startup, crypto, military, political, cult, and sci-fi signals?
4. Does it work in one color?
5. Does it work at favicon and avatar size?
6. Does it fit the Non-Terminal Research website identity?
7. Does it feel durable enough for papers, archives, and long-term use?
8. Does it express openness/revision/non-finality without looking broken?
9. Does the design feel aesthetically strong, not merely conceptually clever?
10. Would QianJun Yu be comfortable using it publicly for years?
11. Does it avoid trying to carry too much theoretical meaning?
12. Does it avoid obvious visual confusion with existing institutions, universities, public agencies, standards bodies, political organizations, military marks, commercial brands, or stock-logo templates?

Automatic Patch Triggers

Patch is required if:

- ? the mark reads as SCE,
- ? the mark looks like a loading spinner,
- ? the mark looks like a target, reticle, scope, or coordinate marker,
- ? the mark feels like an app icon or crypto token,
- ? the mark feels like a political campaign,
- ? the mark uses a mystical seal or cult-like geometry,
- ? the typography is generic or weak,
- ? small-size readability fails,

- ? the design only works in color,
- ? the mark looks like a diagram rather than an identity.
- ? the explanation is stronger than the visual result.
- ? the mark creates plausible confusion with an existing institution, public agency, university, standards body, political mark, military mark, commercial brand, or commonly used stock-logo template.

Automatic Rejection Triggers

Reject if:

- ? SOE is not readable,
- ? it looks militarized,
- ? it looks like a nationalist/political emblem,
- ? it looks like a religious or esoteric movement,
- ? it looks like a game faction,
- ? it looks like a startup product logo,
- ? the designer cannot provide usable rights/source files,
- ? the mark is based on stock/logo-template art.
- ? the mark is knowingly derived from, or materially confusing with, an existing protected identity.

Acceptance Standard

Accept only if the mark is both:

visually strong

and

conceptually appropriate

Concept alone is not enough. A simple, memorable mark with light meaning is better than a heavy symbolic system that looks awkward.